A FORCED COORDINATE WITH NEARLY MAXIMAL ERASURE ENTROPY

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Abstract. The erasure entropy $E_x(f)$ of a Boolean function at a coordinate x is the conditional entropy of the event $x \in U$ given $U \setminus \{x\}$, where U is drawn from the spectral distribution. It is at most the binary entropy of the influence $\mathrm{Inf}_x(f)$, so the ratio E_x/Inf_x is at most about $\log_2(1/\mathrm{Inf}_x)$. We give a monotone function, built from a majority function with one hidden coordinate, in which one coordinate is the only variable lying in both a shortest minterm and a shortest maxterm, and prove that the ratio at that coordinate is asymptotic to this largest value and grows linearly in the number of variables. The proof uses that the phase of the relevant biased Fourier coefficients advances by $\arccos\frac{1}{3}$, an irrational multiple of π.

1. Introduction

For $f\colon \{0,1\}^n \to \{-1,1\}$ write $f = \sum_S \hat{f}(S)\chi_S$ and let U be a random subset with $\Pr[U = S] = \hat{f}(S)^2$. The Fourier entropy-influence conjecture of Friedgut and Kalai [4] asks for an absolute C with $H(U) \le C\,\mathbb{E}|U|$. It is known for symmetric functions and read-once decision trees [15] and is preserved under suitable compositions [14]. Weaker forms and bounds with extra factors are in [1, 17, 7, 5]. Li and Han [9] make the constant in front of $\mathbb{E}|U|$ in Han's bound sharp. The conjecture was proved for every linear threshold function in [24]. The largest known lower bound on the best constant is 6.5218 [12]. Earlier bounds are due to O'Donnell and Tan [14], Hod [6] and Mosaic Intelligence [10, 11]. The erasure entropy of f at a coordinate x is

$$E_x(f) = H\big(\mathbf{1}[x \in U] \;\big|\; U \setminus \{x\}\big),$$

the conditional entropy of one coordinate given the others, in the sense of Verdú and Weissman [16], and with $\mathrm{Inf}_x(f) = \Pr[x \in U]$ the conjecture holds if and only if

$$\sup_f \min_{x\colon \mathrm{Inf}_x(f)>0} \frac{E_x(f)}{\mathrm{Inf}_x(f)}$$

is finite [20], which builds on the reduction of González, MacManus and Pereyra [3] to a statement about one coordinate; coordinates at which the ratio is bounded for some classes of functions are studied in [21]. Since conditioning does not increase entropy,

$$\frac{E_x(f)}{\mathrm{Inf}_x(f)} \le \frac{h_2(\mathrm{Inf}_x(f))}{\mathrm{Inf}_x(f)} \le \log_2 \frac{e}{\mathrm{Inf}_x(f)} \tag{1}$$

for every f and x with $\mathrm{Inf}_x(f) > 0$.

Which coordinate to take is the difficulty. In [22] several natural selection rules are shown to fail on monotone functions, among them the rule that takes, among the variables lying both in a shortest minterm and in a shortest maxterm, one of smallest ratio. For that rule the counterexample is a family $F_{k,t}$ in which a coordinate x is the only variable of both kinds, and the ratio at x is unbounded when k and t grow together. Here we treat the smallest case $t = 1$,

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the simplest member of the family, and find the exact rate of growth; the extension to every fixed t and to every rational bias is in [23].

Fix an odd $k = 2m+1$ and let $y^0 \in \{0,1\}^k$ be the point with $y^0_j = 1$ for $j \le m$ and $y^0_j = 0$ for $j > m$, and $y^1 = y^0 + e_{m+1}$. Let M be the majority function MAJ_k with the point y^1 removed from its true set, and

$$\tilde{f}_k(y,x) = M(y) \vee \big(x \wedge [y \ge y^0]\big).$$

Let F_k be the function of $2k+1$ variables obtained from $\tilde{f}_k$ by replacing y_j with the OR of two fresh variables for $j \le m$ and with the AND of two fresh variables for $j > m$. It is the function $F_{k,1}$ of [22, Section 5]; it is monotone, and x is the only variable that lies both in a shortest minterm and in a shortest maxterm of F_k [22, Section 5].

Theorem 1. $\mathrm{Inf}_x(F_k) = (3/4)^{k-1}$ *and, as* $k \to \infty$ *through odd values,*

$$\frac{E_x(F_k)}{\mathrm{Inf}_x(F_k)} = (1+o(1)) \log_2 \frac{1}{\mathrm{Inf}_x(F_k)} = (1+o(1))\,(k-1) \log_2 \frac{4}{3}.$$

The upper half of the theorem is (1). The exact values computed in Section 5 approach the bound slowly: the quotient of the ratio by $(k-1)\log_2 \frac{4}{3}$ is 0.80 at $k = 21$, 0.88 at $k = 81$ and 0.92 at $k = 141$, increasing along the table, though not monotone in k (its smallest value, 0.796, is at $k = 19$).

2. The ratio as a double sum

All logarithms are to base 2 unless written ln. For $a, b \ge 0$ let $\Phi(a,b) = a \log \frac{a+b}{a} + b \log \frac{a+b}{b}$, with $\Phi(a,0) = \Phi(0,b) = 0$, and $\Psi(r) = \Phi(r^2, 1)$ for $r \ge 0$. Then $\Psi \ge 0$, and $\Psi(r) \ge \log r^2$ for $r \ge 1$, since both terms of Φ are nonnegative and $(r^2+1)/1 \ge r^2$.

Put $P = \frac{3}{4}$ and $q = \frac{1}{4}$. The OR of two uniform bits is true with probability P and the AND with probability q. By the proof of [22, Proposition 12], $E_x(F_k)$ and $\mathrm{Inf}_x(F_k)$ are the erasure entropy and the influence of x for the law $\gamma(S)^2$, where $\gamma(S)$ are the coefficients of $\tilde{f}_k$, in ± 1 values, in the orthonormal basis $\prod_{j \in S} \phi_j(y_j)$ (times $2x-1$ when $x \in S$) of the product measure on (y,x) with $\Pr[y_j = 1] = \mu_j$ and x uniform; here $\mu_j = P$ for $j \le m$, $\mu_j = q$ for $j > m$, and $\phi_j(y) = (y - \mu_j)/\sigma$ with $\sigma = \sqrt{Pq} = \sqrt{3}/4$ (the μ-biased Fourier basis, see [13, Chapter 8]; the conjecture for biased product measures is formulated in [8]).

With $+1$ for true, $\tilde{f}_k = \bar{A} + (2x-1)D$, where

$$D = \mathbf{1}[y = y^0] + \mathbf{1}[y = y^1], \qquad \bar{A} = 2N - 1 + \mathbf{1}[y = y^0] - \mathbf{1}[y = y^1],$$

and $N = \mathbf{1}[|y| \ge m+1]$. For $S \subseteq [k]$ write $u = |S \cap \{1, \dots, m\}|$ and $v = |S \cap \{m+2, \dots, k\}|$, and let $\hat{g}(S)$ denote the coefficient of g at $\prod_{j \in S} \phi_j$. Put

$$X(z) = q + Pz, \qquad Y(z) = P + qz, \qquad H_{uv}(z) = (z-1)^{u+v} X(z)^{m-u} Y(z)^{m+1-v}.$$

Lemma 2. *If* $m+1 \in S$ *then* $\hat{D}(S) = 0$. *If* $m+1 \notin S$ *then*

$$\hat{D}(S) = (-1)^v \sigma^{u+v} P^{2m-u-v}, \qquad \hat{\bar{A}}(S) = 2\sigma^{u+v} t_{uv} - \mathbf{1}[S = \emptyset] + \tfrac{1}{2}\hat{D}(S),$$

where

$$t_{uv} = \sum_{s \ge m+1} [z^s] H_{uv}(z).$$

Proof. For a point w, $\widehat{\mathbf{1}[y=w]}(S) = \Pr[y = w] \prod_{j \in S} \phi_j(w_j)$. For $j \le m$, $y^0_j = 1$ and $\phi_j(1) = q/\sigma = \sqrt{q/P}$; for $j \ge m+2$, $y^0_j = 0$ and $\phi_j(0) = -q/\sigma = -\sqrt{q/P}$. The points y^0 and y^1 differ only at $m+1$, where $\mu_{m+1} = q$, so $\Pr[y = y^0] = P^{2m+1}$ and $\Pr[y = y^1] = P^{2m} q$. If $m+1 \in S$

the two terms of $\hat D(S)$ carry the factors $P^{2m+1}\phi_{m+1}(0) = -P^{2m}\sqrt{Pq}$ and $P^{2m}q\,\phi_{m+1}(1) = P^{2m}\sqrt{Pq}$, which cancel. Otherwise both points give the same product $(-1)^v(q/P)^{(u+v)/2}$, so $\hat D(S) = P^{2m}(-1)^v(q/P)^{(u+v)/2} = (-1)^v\sigma^{u+v}P^{2m-u-v}$ and $\mathbf{1}\widehat{[y=y^0]}(S) - \mathbf{1}\widehat{[y=y^1]}(S) = (P-q)\hat D(S) = \tfrac12\hat D(S)$. Finally $\mathbb{E}[z^{y_j}\phi_j(y_j)] = \mu_j z(1-\mu_j)/\sigma - (1-\mu_j)\mu_j/\sigma = \sigma(z-1)$ and $\mathbb{E}[z^{y_j}] = 1-\mu_j+\mu_j z$, so by independence $\mathbb{E}[z^{|y|}\prod_{j\in S}\phi_j(y_j)] = \sigma^{u+v}H_{uv}(z)$ when $m+1\notin S$, and $\hat N(S)$ is the sum of its coefficients at z^s, $s\ge m+1$. □

Let $\beta_u = \binom{m}{u}q^uP^{m-u}$ be the binomial law with parameters m and q, and for $0\le u,v\le m$ put

$$r_{uv} = \frac{\bigl|2t_{uv} - \mathbf{1}[u=v=0] + \tfrac12(-1)^vP^{2m-u-v}\bigr|}{P^{2m-u-v}}.$$

Lemma 3. $\mathrm{Inf}_x(F_k) = P^{2m} = (3/4)^{k-1}$ *and*

$$\frac{E_x(F_k)}{\mathrm{Inf}_x(F_k)} = \sum_{u,v=0}^{m}\beta_u\beta_v\,\Psi(r_{uv}).$$

Proof. By the reduction above, $E_x = \sum_S \Phi(\hat{\bar A}(S)^2, \hat D(S)^2)$ and $\mathrm{Inf}_x = \sum_S \hat D(S)^2$, the sums over $S\subseteq[k]$; the terms with $m+1\in S$ vanish. There are $\binom{m}{u}\binom{m}{v}$ sets with given u,v and $m+1\notin S$, and $\sum_{u,v}\binom{m}{u}\binom{m}{v}(Pq)^{u+v}P^{2(2m-u-v)} = (Pq+P^2)^{2m} = P^{2m}$. By homogeneity $\Phi(\hat{\bar A}^2,\hat D^2) = \hat D^2\,\Psi(|\hat{\bar A}|/|\hat D|)$, the quotient $|\hat{\bar A}(S)|/|\hat D(S)|$ is r_{uv} by Lemma 2, and $\binom{m}{u}\binom{m}{v}(Pq)^{u+v}P^{2(2m-u-v)}/P^{2m} = \beta_u\beta_v$. □

So E_x/Inf_x is the mean of $\Psi(r_{uv})$ when u and v are independent binomial variables with parameters m and $\frac14$. Most of that law sits near $u=v=m/4$, and the theorem says that there $\log r_{uv}^2$ is close to $2m\log\frac43$ for almost all (u,v). The difficulty is that t_{uv} is a sum of terms of both signs; we show that it oscillates, in u, like the cosine of an irrational rotation times an exponentially large envelope.

3. The tail on the unit circle

Lemma 4. *If $u+v\ge1$ then $Q_{uv} = H_{uv}/(z-1)$ is a polynomial and*

$$t_{uv} = [z^m]\,Q_{uv}(z) = \frac{1}{2\pi}\int_{-\pi}^{\pi}Q_{uv}(e^{\mathrm{i}\theta})\,e^{-\mathrm{i}m\theta}\,d\theta.$$

Proof. Write $Q_{uv} = \sum_s \kappa_s z^s$. Then $[z^s]H_{uv} = \kappa_{s-1} - \kappa_s$, and the sum over $s\ge m+1$ telescopes to κ_m because Q_{uv} has degree one less than H_{uv}. The integral is Cauchy's formula on $|z|=1$; coefficient extraction of this kind, followed by a Laplace or saddle-point estimate, is standard [2, Chapter VIII]. □

On the circle the three factors of Q_{uv} have explicit moduli. For $z = e^{\mathrm{i}\theta}$ and $w = \cos\theta$,

$$|z-1|^2 = 2-2w, \qquad |X(z)|^2 = |Y(z)|^2 = q^2+P^2+2Pqw = \frac{5+3w}{8}.$$

Put $n_1 = u+v-1$ and $n_2 = 2m+1-u-v$, so that $n_1+n_2 = 2m$. Then $|Q_{uv}(e^{\mathrm{i}\theta})| = e^{\rho(\cos\theta)}$ with

$$\rho(w) = \frac{n_1}{2}\ln(2-2w) + \frac{n_2}{2}\ln\frac{5+3w}{8}, \qquad \rho''(w) = -\frac{n_1}{2(1-w)^2} - \frac{9n_2}{2(5+3w)^2} \le -\frac{9n_2}{128}.$$

So ρ is strictly concave on $[-1,1)$; its maximum is at $w_0=(3n_2-5n_1)/(6m)$ when this lies in $(-1,1)$, and a short computation gives $2-2w_0=8n_1/(3m)$, $(5+3w_0)/8=n_2/(2m)$, hence

$$\rho(w_0)=\frac{n_1}{2}\ln\frac{8n_1}{3m}+\frac{n_2}{2}\ln\frac{n_2}{2m}. \tag{2}$$

At $u=v=m/4$ one has $n_1\approx m/2$, $w_0\approx\frac13$ and $e^{\rho(w_0)}\approx(\sqrt3/2)^m$.

For $\lambda\ge1$ let W_λ be the set of (u,v) with $|u-m/4|\le\lambda\sqrt m$ and $|v-m/4|\le\lambda\sqrt m$. In what follows c,C denote positive constants that may depend on λ but not on m or on $(u,v)\in W_\lambda$, and m is large enough for each statement. On W_λ, $n_1=m/2+O(\sqrt m)$ and $w_0=\frac13+O(m^{-1/2})$; put $\theta_0=\arccos w_0$, $\theta^*=\arccos\frac13$ and $z_0=e^{\mathrm i\theta_0}$.

Lemma 5. *On W_λ, $\rho(w_0)+(n_2-1)\ln\frac43\ge(m-1)\ln\frac43$.*

Proof. Regard the left side, by (2), as a function $G(n_1)$ of a real variable $n_1\in(0,2m)$, with $n_2=2m-n_1$. Then $G'(n_1)=\frac12\ln\frac{16n_1}{3n_2}-\ln\frac43$, which vanishes at $n_1=m/2$, and $G''(n_1)=\frac{1}{2n_1}+\frac{1}{2n_2}>0$. So G is convex with its minimum at $m/2$, and $G(m/2)=\frac{m}{4}\ln\frac43+\frac{3m}{4}\ln\frac34+(\frac{3m}{2}-1)\ln\frac43=(m-1)\ln\frac43$. □

Fix $(u,v)\in W_\lambda$ and let $\Lambda(\theta)=\ln Q_{uv}(e^{\mathrm i\theta})-\mathrm im\theta$, for complex θ with $|\theta-\theta^*|\le\delta$, where $\delta>0$ is so small that $e^{\mathrm i\theta}$ stays away from 1, $-\frac13$ and -3, the zeros of $z-1$, X and Y; the logarithm is the branch continuous in this disc. Since Λ is a sum of at most $2m+1$ logarithms of functions analytic and nonvanishing there, plus a linear term, $|\Lambda''|$ and $|\Lambda'''|$ are at most Cm on the disc. For real θ, $\operatorname{Re}\Lambda(\theta)=\rho(\cos\theta)$, so $\operatorname{Re}\Lambda'(\theta_0)=-\rho'(w_0)\sin\theta_0=0$ and $\operatorname{Re}\Lambda''(\theta_0)=\rho''(w_0)\sin^2\theta_0\le-cm$. Put

$$b=\operatorname{Im}\Lambda'(\theta_0),\qquad A=-\Lambda''(\theta_0),\qquad T_{uv}=\frac{1}{\sqrt{2\pi A}}\exp\Big(\Lambda(\theta_0)-\frac{b^2}{2A}\Big),$$

with the principal square root ($\operatorname{Re}A>0$).

Lemma 6. *On W_λ: $|b|\le C\sqrt m$, $|T_{uv}|\ge c\,m^{-1/2}e^{\rho(w_0)}$, and $t_{uv}=2\operatorname{Re}T_{uv}+O(|T_{uv}|\,m^{-1/5})$.*

Proof. Write $a=u/m$, $a'=v/m$. Then $\Lambda'(\theta)/m$ differs by $O(1/m)$ from $\mathrm iz\big(\frac{a+a'}{z-1}+\frac{(1-a)P}{X}+\frac{(1-a')q}{Y}\big)-\mathrm i$ at $z=e^{\mathrm i\theta}$, which is a smooth function of (a,a',θ) and vanishes at $a=a'=\frac14$, $\theta=\theta^*$: there $z^*=e^{\mathrm i\theta^*}=\frac13+\frac{2\sqrt2}{3}\mathrm i$, and $\frac{1}{2(z^*-1)}+\frac{9}{16X(z^*)}+\frac{3}{16Y(z^*)}=\frac{1}{z^*}$, as one checks from $X(z^*)=\frac12+\frac{\sqrt2}{2}\mathrm i$ and $Y(z^*)=\frac56+\frac{\sqrt2}{6}\mathrm i$. Since $a-\frac14$, $a'-\frac14$ and $\theta_0-\theta^*$ are $O(m^{-1/2})$, $|\Lambda'(\theta_0)|\le C\sqrt m$, which bounds b. Next, $\operatorname{Re}(b^2/A)=b^2\operatorname{Re}A/|A|^2\le C$, so $|T_{uv}|\ge c\,|A|^{-1/2}|e^{\Lambda(\theta_0)}|\ge c\,m^{-1/2}e^{\rho(w_0)}$.

By Lemma 4, $t_{uv}=\frac{1}{2\pi}\int_{-\pi}^{\pi}e^{\Lambda(\theta)}d\theta$, the integrand being $Q_{uv}(e^{\mathrm i\theta})e^{-\mathrm im\theta}$ on the whole circle. Split the interval into $J_+=\{|\theta-\theta_0|\le m^{-2/5}\}$, $J_-=-J_+$ and the rest. On J_+, with $\theta=\theta_0+h$, $\Lambda(\theta)=\Lambda(\theta_0)+\mathrm ibh-\frac12Ah^2+R(h)$ with $|R(h)|\le Cm|h|^3\le Cm^{-1/5}$. Hence

$$\frac{1}{2\pi}\int_{J_+}e^{\Lambda}=\frac{e^{\Lambda(\theta_0)}}{2\pi}\Big(\int_{\mathbb R}e^{\mathrm ibh-Ah^2/2}dh-\int_{|h|>m^{-2/5}}e^{\mathrm ibh-Ah^2/2}dh\Big)+O\Big(e^{\rho(w_0)}m^{-1/5}\int_{\mathbb R}e^{-cmh^2}dh\Big).$$

The first integral is $\sqrt{2\pi/A}\,e^{-b^2/(2A)}$, which makes the first term T_{uv}; the second is at most $Ce^{-cm^{1/5}}$; the error term is $O(e^{\rho(w_0)}m^{-1/2-1/5})=O(|T_{uv}|m^{-1/5})$. The coefficients of Q_{uv} are real, so the integral over J_- is the complex conjugate. Off $J_+\cup J_-$, for $\theta\in[0,\pi]$, $|\cos\theta-\cos\theta_0|=2\sin\frac{\theta+\theta_0}{2}\big|\sin\frac{\theta-\theta_0}{2}\big|\ge c|\theta-\theta_0|$ because θ_0 stays away from 0 and π, and likewise for $\theta\in[-\pi,0]$; since $\rho'(w_0)=0$ and $\rho''\le-9n_2/128\le-cm$, the integrand there has modulus at most $e^{\rho(w_0)-cm(\cos\theta-w_0)^2}\le e^{\rho(w_0)-cm^{1/5}}$, which is $O(|T_{uv}|m^{-1/5})$ after integration. □

Lemma 7. *Let $\alpha=\arccos\frac13$. If (u,v) and $(u+1,v)$ lie in W_λ, then $\arg T_{u+1,v}-\arg T_{uv}=\alpha+O(m^{-1/2})$ modulo 2π.*

Proof. Let $K(z) = (z-1)/X(z)$, so that $Q_{u+1,v} = KQ_{uv}$, and denote by Λ^+, θ_0^+, b^+, A^+ the quantities for $(u+1,v)$. Here $\Lambda^+ = \Lambda + \ln K(e^{\mathrm{i}\theta})$, and w_0 changes by $-4/(3m)$, so $\theta_0^+ - \theta_0 = O(1/m)$. Hence

$$\Lambda^+(\theta_0^+) - \Lambda(\theta_0) = \ln K(z_0) + \Lambda'(\theta_0)(\theta_0^+ - \theta_0) + O(1/m) = \ln K(z_0) + O(m^{-1/2})$$

by Lemma 6. Similarly $A^+ - A = O(1)$ and $b^+ - b = O(1)$, so $\arg A$ moves by $O(1/m)$ and $b^2/(2A)$ by $O(|b|/m + b^2/m^2) = O(m^{-1/2})$. So $\arg T$ moves by $\operatorname{Im} \ln K(z_0) + O(m^{-1/2})$. Finally $K(z^*) = \frac{4}{3}z^*$, as $(z^*-1)\overline{X(z^*)} = \frac{1}{3} + \frac{2\sqrt{2}}{3}\mathrm{i}$ and $|X(z^*)|^2 = \frac{3}{4}$; thus $\arg K(z^*) = \theta^* = \alpha$, and $z_0 - z^* = O(m^{-1/2})$. □

The number α/π is irrational: by Niven's theorem [19], if α/π is rational and $\cos\alpha$ is rational then $\cos\alpha \in \{0, \pm\frac{1}{2}, \pm 1\}$.

4. Proof of the theorem

The equality $\mathrm{Inf}_x(F_k) = (3/4)^{k-1}$ is Lemma 3, and the upper bound is (1). For the lower bound fix $\varepsilon \in (0, \frac{1}{4})$, $\lambda \geq 1$ and an integer $L \geq 1$. Since α/π is irrational, the sequence $\ell\alpha/\pi$ is equidistributed modulo 1 [18], with discrepancy tending to 0; the set of ψ modulo π with $|\cos\psi| < 2\varepsilon$ is an interval of length $2\arcsin 2\varepsilon \leq 2\pi\varepsilon$. So we may take L so large that for every real ψ_0 at most $3\varepsilon L$ of the numbers $\ell = 0, \dots, L-1$ satisfy $|\cos(\psi_0 + \ell\alpha)| < 2\varepsilon$.

Fix v and cut the set of u with $(u,v) \in W_\lambda$ into consecutive blocks of L values, leaving at most $L-1$ values over. In a block starting at u_0, Lemma 7 gives $\arg T_{u_0+\ell,v} = \arg T_{u_0,v} + \ell\alpha + O(Lm^{-1/2})$ for $\ell < L$, and for m large the error is below ε, so at most $3\varepsilon L$ values of u in the block have $|\cos\arg T_{uv}| < \varepsilon$. On W_λ, $\beta_{u+1}/\beta_u = (m-u)/(3(u+1)) = 1 + O(m^{-1/2})$, so the weights β_u in a block differ by a factor at most 2 for m large, and the bad values carry at most 6ε of the block's weight. The left-over values carry weight at most $(L-1)\max_u \beta_u = O(Lm^{-1/2})$ in each row. Summing over v, the pairs $(u,v) \in W_\lambda$ with $|\cos\arg T_{uv}| < \varepsilon$, together with the left-over ones, have $\beta_u\beta_v$-weight at most $6\varepsilon + o(1)$.

Let $(u,v) \in W_\lambda$ have $|\cos\arg T_{uv}| \geq \varepsilon$. By Lemma 6, $|t_{uv}| \geq 2\varepsilon|T_{uv}| - C|T_{uv}|m^{-1/5} \geq \varepsilon|T_{uv}| \geq c\varepsilon m^{-1/2}e^{\rho(w_0)}$, and $(u,v) \neq (0,0)$. With $2m - u - v = n_2 - 1$ and Lemma 5,

$$r_{uv} \geq \frac{2|t_{uv}|}{P^{n_2-1}} - \frac{1}{2} \geq c\varepsilon m^{-1/2}\Big(\frac{4}{3}\Big)^m - \frac{1}{2},$$

which exceeds 1 for m large, and then $\Psi(r_{uv}) \geq \log r_{uv}^2 \geq 2m\log\frac{4}{3} - \log m - C_\varepsilon$. By Chebyshev's inequality $\Pr[|u - m/4| > \lambda\sqrt{m}] \leq \frac{3}{16\lambda^2}$, so W_λ has weight at least $(1 - \frac{3}{16\lambda^2})^2$. Since $\Psi \geq 0$, Lemma 3 gives

$$\frac{E_x(F_k)}{\mathrm{Inf}_x(F_k)} \geq \Big(\big(1 - \tfrac{3}{16\lambda^2}\big)^2 - 6\varepsilon - o(1)\Big)\Big(2m\log\frac{4}{3} - \log m - C_\varepsilon\Big).$$

As $2m = k-1$, dividing by $(k-1)\log\frac{4}{3}$ and letting $m \to \infty$, then $\lambda \to \infty$ and $\varepsilon \to 0$, gives $\liminf \geq 1$. □

Remark 8. In v the factor is $(z-1)/Y$, and $(z^*-1)/Y(z^*) = \frac{4}{3}(-\frac{1}{3} + \frac{2\sqrt{2}}{3}\mathrm{i})$, so the phase step is $\pi - \alpha$ and the step from (u,v) to $(u+1,v+1)$ is π: to first order the sign of t_{uv} alternates along diagonals.

5. Numerical checks

Lemma 3 turns the ratio into a double sum of $(m+1)^2$ terms whose ingredients are integers over powers of 4, so the coefficients can be computed exactly in rational arithmetic; each term of Φ is then evaluated as $a\log(1 + b/a)$ with a $\log(1+\cdot)$ routine, since a/b exceeds 10^{17} from

$k = 35$ on and is about $2 \cdot 10^{69}$ at $k = 121$. The ratio $R_k = E_x(F_k)/\mathrm{Inf}_x(F_k)$ and the quotient $R_k/((k-1)\log\frac{4}{3})$ are:

k	R_k	quotient	k	R_k	quotient
21	6.631	0.799	101	37.249	0.898
41	13.826	0.833	121	45.276	0.909
61	21.448	0.861	133	50.138	0.915
81	29.311	0.883	141	53.319	0.918

For $k = 3, 5, 7, 9$ the values 1.0512, 1.8769, 2.5690, 3.1179 agree to 10^{-9} with the ratio computed from the full Walsh–Hadamard transform of F_k on 7, 11, 15 and 19 variables, which also confirms that x is the only variable in both a shortest minterm and a shortest maxterm. The Laplace approximation of Lemma 6 was compared with the exact t_{uv} over all of W_1: the largest error relative to $|T_{uv}|$ is 0.149, 0.095 and 0.071 at $k = 41$, 81 and 141, about $0.6\,m^{-1/2}$. Since ρ is strictly concave and cos is decreasing on $(0, \pi)$, $|Q_{uv}(e^{\mathrm{i}\theta})| = e^{\rho(\cos\theta)}$ has no local maximum on $(0, \pi)$ other than θ_0.

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Declaration of competing interest

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Declaration of generative AI and AI-assisted technologies

The paper comes out of Math Brain, a project on the use of AI systems in research mathematics [27, 25]. The family $F_{k,t}$ is from [22]. Claude Opus 5.5 (Anthropic) found Theorem 1 and its proof, wrote the numerical checks and prepared the manuscript. The author directed the work and is responsible for the content of the paper.

Code and data availability

Code and outputs: `https://github.com/yspennstate/fei-forced-coordinate`, archived on Zenodo with doi:10.5281/zenodo.24126356.

The paper is part of the Math Brain project, whose public repository is `https://github.com/yspennstate/math-brain-public` [25].

Appendix A. Notation

Symbols are listed roughly in the order in which they first appear, and the last column gives that place.

Symbol	Meaning	First appears
f, $\hat{f}(S)$, χ_S	a Boolean function $\{0,1\}^n \to \{-1,1\}$, its Fourier coefficient at S, and the character at S	Section 1
n	the number of variables of f	Section 1
U	a random subset with $\Pr[U = S] = \hat{f}(S)^2$	Section 1
C	an absolute constant, as in $H(U) \le C\,\mathbb{E}\lvert U\rvert$	Section 1
x	a coordinate; for F_k, the coordinate lying in both a shortest minterm and a shortest maxterm	Section 1
$E_x(f)$, $\mathrm{Inf}_x(f)$	the erasure entropy $H(\mathbf{1}[x \in U] \mid U \setminus \{x\})$, and the influence $\Pr[x \in U]$	Section 1
h_2	the binary entropy	Section 1
$F_{k,t}$	the family of monotone functions of [22, Section 5]	Section 1
k, m	the odd number of inputs of the majority, and $m = (k-1)/2$	Section 1
y^0, y^1	the point of $\{0,1\}^k$ with ones exactly in the first m places, and $y^0 + e_{m+1}$	Section 1
MAJ_k, M	the majority function on k bits, and the same with y^1 removed from its true set	Section 1
$\tilde{f}_k$, F_k	$M(y) \vee (x \wedge [y \ge y^0])$, and the function on $2k+1$ variables obtained from it by replacing each y_j with an OR or an AND of two fresh variables	Section 1
$\Phi(a,b)$, $\Psi(r)$	$a \log \frac{a+b}{a} + b \log \frac{a+b}{b}$, and $\Phi(r^2, 1)$	Section 2
P, q	$\frac{3}{4}$ and $\frac{1}{4}$, the probabilities that an OR and an AND of two uniform bits are true	Section 2
$\gamma(S)$	the coefficients of $\tilde{f}_k$ in the biased basis	Section 2
μ_j, ϕ_j, σ	the bias of y_j, the biased basis function $(y - \mu_j)/\sigma$, and $\sigma = \sqrt{Pq}$	Section 2
D, $\bar{A}$, N	the odd and even parts of $\tilde{f}_k$ in x, and the indicator $\mathbf{1}[\lvert y\rvert \ge m+1]$	Section 2
u, v	$\lvert S \cap \{1,\dots,m\}\rvert$ and $\lvert S \cap \{m+2,\dots,k\}\rvert$	Section 2
$\hat{g}(S)$	the coefficient of a function g at $\prod_{j \in S} \phi_j$	Section 2
z	a complex variable	Section 2
X, Y, H_{uv}	$q + Pz$, $P + qz$, and $(z-1)^{u+v} X^{m-u} Y^{m+1-v}$	Section 2
$[z^s]$, t_{uv}	the coefficient of z^s, and $\sum_{s \ge m+1} [z^s] H_{uv}$	Lemma 2
β_u, r_{uv}	the binomial law $\binom{m}{u} q^u P^{m-u}$, and the quotient $\lvert\hat{\bar{A}}(S)\rvert / \lvert\hat{D}(S)\rvert$ for sets of type (u,v)	Section 2
Q_{uv}, κ_s	$H_{uv}/(z-1)$, and its coefficients, in the proof	Lemma 4
θ, w	the angle with $z = e^{\mathrm{i}\theta}$, and $w = \cos\theta$	Lemma 4
n_1, n_2	$u + v - 1$ and $2m + 1 - u - v$	Section 3
$\rho(w)$, w_0	$\ln \lvert Q_{uv}(e^{\mathrm{i}\theta})\rvert$ as a function of w, and its maximum point	Section 3
λ, W_λ	a width, and the pairs (u,v) within $\lambda\sqrt{m}$ of $(m/4, m/4)$ in each coordinate	Section 3

Symbol	Meaning	First appears
c, C	positive constants that may depend on λ but not on m or (u, v)	Section 3
θ_0, θ^*, z_0	$\arccos w_0$, $\arccos \frac{1}{3}$, and $e^{\mathrm{i}\theta_0}$	Section 3
$G(n_1)$	the left side of the lemma as a function of n_1, in the proof	Lemma 5
$\Lambda(\theta)$, δ	$\ln Q_{uv}(e^{\mathrm{i}\theta}) - \mathrm{i}m\theta$ on a small disc around θ^*, and the radius of that disc	Section 3
b, A, T_{uv}	$\operatorname{Im}\Lambda'(\theta_0)$, $-\Lambda''(\theta_0)$, and the Laplace term $(2\pi A)^{-1/2}\exp(\Lambda(\theta_0) - b^2/(2A))$	Section 3
a, a', z^*	u/m, v/m, and $e^{\mathrm{i}\theta^*}$, in the proof	Lemma 6
$J_\pm$, h, $R(h)$	the arcs $\lvert\theta \mp \theta_0\rvert \le m^{-2/5}$, the offset $\theta - \theta_0$, and the cubic remainder, in the proof	Lemma 6
α	$\arccos \frac{1}{3}$, an irrational multiple of π	Lemma 7
$K(z)$, Λ^+	$(z-1)/X(z)$, and Λ for the pair $(u+1, v)$, in the proof	Lemma 7
ε, L	a small number and a block length	Section 4
ψ_0, ℓ, u_0	a phase, an index in a block, and the first u of a block	Section 4
C_ε	a constant depending on ε	Section 4
R_k	the ratio $E_x(F_k)/\mathrm{Inf}_x(F_k)$	Section 5

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